

The “Saying No” Script Pack

30 things to say when you don't have the energy to find your own words. Plus 5 templates for the conversations you keep putting off.

A note before you start

I made this when I realized I'd been saying yes to visits I didn't want, advice I didn't ask for, and “just one quick stop-by” texts I hadn't recovered from.

It's not because I'm bad at boundaries. It's because my brain stopped giving me sentences. Postpartum exhaustion eats words first.

So here are the words. Pre-made. Use them, modify them, hand them to your partner. None of these scripts require you to justify yourself. Saying no is a complete sentence — but if you want a softer landing, that's here too.

You don't owe anyone access to your body, your baby, your house, or your decisions. Not your in-laws. Not your best friend. Not your mother. The fact that they love you doesn't entitle them to your fourth trimester.

— Soothemade

This is a planning tool, not advice for your specific situation. Trust your instincts and call your providers when something feels off.

Section 1 — Hospital visitors (5 scripts)

Script 1.1 — The pre-emptive announcement (send before birth)

Hi everyone — quick note as we head into the home stretch. We're not having any visitors at the hospital. We'll share photos as soon as we can, and we'll let you know when we're ready for people to come meet [baby] at home. Thanks for understanding — it means a lot.



Script 1.2 — When someone “just stops by” anyway

Hey — thanks for thinking of us. We're not seeing visitors right now. I'll text you when we're ready. Appreciate it.

Script 1.3 — The “I had no idea” person

Oh — I'm so sorry, I should have been clearer. We're not having any visitors this trip. Let me text you when we're back home and settled, and we'll set up a real visit then.

Script 1.4 — For your partner to use at the door

Hey [name], thanks for coming by. [Birthing parent] is resting and can't have visitors right now. I'll have them text you when they're up for it.

Script 1.5 — For the nurses (a sign for the door)

Please print and tape to the hospital room door.

Welcome — we're so glad to meet our new baby and we appreciate your interest in our family. We are not accepting visitors at this time. We will share updates and photos when we can. If you have a delivery or a question, please leave a note with the front desk. Thank you.

Section 2 — First week at home (5 scripts)

Script 2.1 — The “can I come hold the baby?” text

Thanks for thinking of us! We’re not ready for visitors yet — the first couple weeks we’re keeping it small. I’ll let you know when we’re ready. ❤️

Script 2.2 — The “I’ll bring food and just drop it off!” person

That is so kind of you. If you really want to help — could you leave it on the porch? We’re keeping the house quiet right now. We’ll text you a thank-you when we surface.

Script 2.3 — The “but I won’t stay long” person

I know you mean well — and I appreciate it. For us “short visits” still cost us a recovery day right now. Can we plan something properly in [X weeks] instead?

Script 2.4 — The mother-in-law who arrived at the door uninvited

[MIL name] — I love that you wanted to surprise us. I’m not in a state to host right now. Can I call you in a few hours and we’ll plan a real visit?

Script 2.5 — When the visitor wants to hold the baby and they’re sick

Hey — I see you’ve got a bit of a cough/cold. We’re being really careful with [baby]’s exposure right now. Can we reschedule for when you’re 100%?

Section 3 — Unsolicited advice (8 scripts)

Script 3.1 — The “you should really be doing X” person

Thanks — we’re following our pediatrician’s recommendations on that. Appreciate you looking out for us.

Script 3.2 — The “in my day we...” person

I love hearing about how you did it. We’re trying things our way and figuring it out as we go.

Script 3.3 — The breastfeeding-opinion person

Feeding is going well for us. I’m not really looking for input on this one.

Script 3.4 — The sleep-training-opinion person

We’re working it out with our pediatrician. Thanks for caring.

Script 3.5 — The body-comment person (“you look so [X]!”)

“Thanks!” — and walk away. No second sentence required.

Script 3.6 — The “is the baby getting enough?” person

The baby is doing great. Thanks for asking.

Script 3.7 — The “you’re going to spoil that baby” person

You can’t spoil a baby this young. The research is pretty clear. But thanks!

Script 3.8 — The “when are you having the next one?” person

Oh that’s a long way off. We’re focused on this one right now.

Section 4 — Visitor-pressure family (6 scripts)

Script 4.1 — The “we’re driving four hours, we have to see the baby” relative

I love that you want to be part of this. We are not seeing anyone right now for [X] weeks. I know that’s hard — I’m sorry. We will set up a real visit when we’re ready.

Script 4.2 — The “your mother is heartbroken she hasn’t met the baby” guilt-tripper

I know. I love her. We’re doing it on our timeline. She’ll meet [baby] when we’re ready.

Script 4.3 — The “but everyone else got to see the baby” comparison

What works for one person doesn’t work for everyone. We’re doing this our way.

Script 4.4 — The “I waited this long, I deserve to hold them” person

I appreciate your patience. We’re not at the holding-the-baby stage yet for [reason — illness, RSV season, my recovery, whatever]. We’ll get there.

Script 4.5 — When a family member just shows up

[Name], I love you, and I cannot host you right now. I need you to go. I’ll call you tomorrow.

Script 4.6 — The “you’ll regret keeping the baby from family” guilt

I’m doing what I think is right for my family right now. I won’t regret protecting [baby] in the first weeks.

Section 5 — Photo & social media (3 scripts)

Script 5.1 — The “can I share this picture?” relative

Thanks for asking! We're keeping [baby] off social media for now. Please keep our photos private.

Script 5.2 — When a relative already posted

Hi — I see you posted that photo of [baby]. We've decided to keep [their] photos off social media. Can you take it down? I really appreciate it.

Script 5.3 — The grandparent who wants a “professional shoot ASAP”

We will do photos when we're ready. Right now we're just focused on getting through the first weeks.

Section 6 — Body & emotional commentary (3 scripts)

Script 6.1 — The “you look tired” / “have you slept?” person

Yes. Postpartum.

(That’s the whole script. Use as needed.)

Script 6.2 — The “are you sure you’re okay?” with a worried face

I’m doing what I need to do. If something changes I’ll let you know.

Script 6.3 — The “you should be enjoying every minute” person

Smile. Pause. “Some minutes are better than others.” Then change the topic.

TEMPLATES — for the conversations you keep putting off

Template 1 — The pre-baby family text

Subject: Heads up for baby's arrival

Hi everyone,

As [we / I] get closer to baby's arrival, [we / I] wanted to share how [we're / I'm] handling the first few weeks. Please don't take any of this personally — these are decisions [we've / I've] made for [our / my] mental and physical health.

1. No hospital visitors. We will share photos as soon as we can.
2. No visitors at our home for the first [2 / 3 / 4] weeks. We will reach out individually when we're ready for visits.
3. Please don't drop by unannounced — even if it's "just a quick stop." We will not be answering the door.
4. If you'd like to help in those first weeks, the most useful things are: meals on the porch (no need to come in), gift cards for food delivery, or just a "thinking of you" text. Please don't take it personally if we don't respond right away.
5. Please don't share photos of [baby] on social media. We'll let you know when (or if) that's okay with us.

Thank you for understanding. We love you all and we're excited for [baby] to meet you when we're ready.

— [your name]

Template 2 — The “I changed my mind” follow-up

Hi [name],

I know I said [X], and I want to be honest — that's not working for us anymore. We need to [change to Y].

I know this might be disappointing. I'm not in a place to over-explain it right now. I hope you can understand.

[your name]

Template 3 — The “we need space” hard conversation

[Family member name],

I love you. I need to be honest about something that's been hard for me.

When you [specific thing — drop by unannounced / comment on the baby's weight / give me parenting advice / etc.], it's making my recovery harder, not easier.

I'm not asking you to stop loving us or stop wanting to be involved. I'm asking you to [specific request: please call before coming / please keep parenting advice to yourself unless I ask / please drop food on the porch instead of coming in].

I'd like for us to be close again. Right now I need this from you.

[your name]

Template 4 — The “no presents at the shower” boundary

We are so excited to celebrate with you. As a small ask — please no gifts. We have everything we need, and our space is small.

If you really want to give us something, we'd love a frozen meal, a gift card for [grocery / restaurant delivery], or simply your company.

Thank you for understanding!

Template 5 — The “thanks but no” gift script (for unwanted hand-me-downs, religious items, etc.)

[Name], thank you so much for thinking of [baby]. This is really generous of you.

We've decided that [reason — we're not using X / we don't have space for Y / we're going a different direction with Z]. I hope you don't take this personally.

If it's okay with you, we'll [pass it along / donate it / return it].

Thanks for understanding!

How to use this pack

1. **Print it.** Or save to your phone. The point is having the words before you need them.
 2. **Modify freely.** Replace [name], [X weeks], specifics. The scripts work as starting points.
 3. **Share with your partner.** They'll need scripts too. Different ones.
 4. **Don't justify.** "No" is a sentence. Adding reasons gives someone something to argue with.
 5. **Repeat as needed.** Boundaries aren't a one-time conversation. Some people need to hear it three times.
 6. **Forgive yourself for changing your mind.** Saying yes one week and no the next is fine. Your needs change.
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A last note

Some of the people you set boundaries with are going to be hurt. Some are going to be angry. Some are going to tell other people you're being "selfish" or "hormonal" or "not yourself right now."

You are yourself. You are exactly yourself. You're just yourself with new information about what you need.

The right people will respect you for this. The wrong people will reveal themselves.

Either outcome is useful.

— Soothemade

This product is for planning and personal use only. It is not legal, medical, or psychological advice. If you are experiencing thoughts of harming yourself or your baby, please call the Maternal Mental Health Hotline at 1-833-852-6262 (US) or your local emergency services.